

Unranked, undermined, undeterred

A team once outside the top 100 is now ranked 52 — India's volleyball players have **earned their moment**, even if the system has done little to help them get there.

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The Indian men's volleyball team deserves more credit than it has received in recent times — for what it has achieved despite a system that has offered little support.

Since the Sports Ministry formed an ad-hoc Committee for the Volleyball Federation of India in June 2023, there have been very few exposure trips for the national team.

Yet, against all odds, the team proved its critics wrong with a commendable performance at the 2023 Asian Games in September.

India topped Pool C, defeating Cambodia, three-time champion and 2018 silver medallist Korea, and 2018 bronze medallist Chinese Taipei, before falling to World No. 5 Japan in the quarterfinals.

Following the Asian Games, the ad-hoc Committee continued to function, but the national team saw little action in terms of competitive tournaments.

So when the Central Asian Volleyball Association (CAVA) Nations Men's League — moved from Islamabad to Fergana, Uzbekistan

due to security concerns — came around, few gave India a chance. It was India's first appearance in the tournament, now in its third edition, and notably the first time world ranking points were allocated by the FIVB.

Defying expectations, India — featuring debutants K. Anand (libero) and M. C. Mujeeb (blocker) — exceeded predictions once again, reaching the final before losing to World No. 15 Iran.

This was a significant result for a team ranked 52 in the world, having languished outside the top 100 not long ago. Much of the credit goes to head coach Dragan Mihailovic, a FIVB Instructor and High-Performance coach from Serbia.

Senior players Ashwal Rai, A. Muthusamy, and Jerome Vinith, who played key roles in India's campaign, spoke highly of Mihailovic's methods.

"Their (foreigners') system is different compared to Indian coaches. The main thing is analysing. And they concentrate on every position such as outside hitter, opposite, blocker. They analyse everyone and show videos of opponents and our play," said

blocker Ashwal Rai.

Setter A. Muthusamy echoed Ashwal's view.

"He was positive and though the Bengaluru camp was short (three weeks), we were positive. The competition within the team was tough as there was fight for each position. Dragan did a great job in getting the team together," he said.

Muthusamy also noted areas for improvement.

"Our blockers were brilliant and played a huge role in us doing well," he said. "But we need to improve in service and receiving."

Attacker Jerome Vinith highlighted the tactical leap under Mihailovic.

"Dragan added many new things. A lot of new techniques were introduced by the Serbian, not just in using power but how to use it skillfully. He taught us the way to reach international volleyball," said Jerome.

Placed in Pool A alongside Iran, host Uzbekistan, and Turkmenistan, India began with a 1-3 loss to Iran before securing wins over the remaining teams to finish second in the group.

Pakistan topped Pool B, followed by Kazakhstan.